Clockwise from left: Along the Athens Riviera, Cape Sounion, boasts the 5th century Temple of Poseidon; Superlative Riesling wine is one of the reasons to visit the Moselle Valley as is the river cruise; Community based tourism implies an abundance of local encounters in villages along the Sigatoka River in Fiji.

Moselle Valley, Germany

If a road trip along a soothing waterway for delicious wine, glorious vineyards, and historic towns draws you in, you're only human. I begin this wine-soaked adventure at the impossibly pretty town of Traben Trarbach. Around 1900, Traben-Trarbach was one of the most important wine trading towns. The reason for this accolade was its production of superlative Riesling wine. Fringed by the Moselle River and unfurling vineyards, it is now possible to explore the Traben-Trarbach historic cellars and learn in the semi-darkness about historic viticulture. When you want a break from wine sampling at quaint wineries, like Emil Franz that was founded over a hundred years ago, there's plenty of Art Nouveau and Belle Epoque buildings to be oohed over. Another hour-and-a-half along the Moselle River from Traben–Trabach to Cochem is another gem of a town, strewn with castle, vineyards, half-timbered buildings, medieval charm and heart-stopping views. Also growing in popularity is a cruise along the Moselle River (the German section flows from Trier to Koblenz), with stops to drink in (if you'll pardon the pun) the wonder of these vineyard-laced towns.







Wild Ride, Fiji

I imagine that it's going to be a thrill-a-minute tour. After all, I've signed up to travel along the Sigatoka river aboard a custom-built jet boat, with Sigatoka River Safari. I expect to cry out with excitement, at the 360-degree spins on the twists and turns of the river; but instead the ride for much of the way—barring a few exhilarating spins, is gentle. On the banks of the river, scenes of village life unfold. These unfolding images are interspersed with the guide's narration of stories and legends, some going way back to the days of cannibalism.

What's underscored as we go along is the fact that the River Safari company works with different villages along the route, to minimise the adverse impact of tourism on the daily lives of people. If one's choice of clothing doesn't quite match the prescribed dress code of the village to which one is headed, one is given a sulu or sarong to wear. Traditionally one makes an offering (sevusevu) to the chief on arrival at a village; Yaqona (Kava) being typically what's offered. While the ceremony that unfolds post this offering, and the subsequent sharing of a giant bowl of kava, may be organised especially for us, these customs themselves are firmly entrenched in local life. The warmth of a community eager to share their traditions, stories and ideas is palpable, in the feasting, singing and (very enthusiastic) dancing that follows. That part of the ticket price goes back to help with village projects—water, education, health—gives heart to the words 'community-based tourism."